

TOMMY FITZGERALD

Garagiola's All-Italians: Berra, Rizzuto, Stengelli



"Just call me Joe because I don't want anybody to get lockjaw on Good Friday," Joe Garagiola told the telephone operator who was choking on his surname as he answered a call to St. Petersburg Beach yesterday.

An all-star baseball team from Italy is in Miami for some exhibitions. With "Italia" emblazoned across their shirt-fronts, you sort of expected to see Roman numerals — IV, XII, etc. — on their backs instead of finding the conventional Arabic. You concluded that nothing funny happened on the way to the seamstress, but that Italian baseball simply has been more influenced by Julius LaRosa than Julius Caesar. In fact, they mostly hit like LaRosa.

This first visit of an Italian team to America and, specifically, to Miami reminded citizens of the great contribution Italian-Americans have made to our so-called National Pastime. It prompted the writer as an appropriate occasion on which to seek out Mr. Garagiola, the sportcaster, ex-big league baseball catcher, raconteur, wit and spaghetti-eater, and ask him to select an all-time, all-Italian big league team.

"Ernie Lombardi and Yogi Berra — for the left-handed hitter — would be my catchers, but I'd have to include Pignatano," Joe began after deliberating the matter. "Pignatano would look nicer on the scoreboard. Such a beautiful opera-sounding name."

Italian By Marriage

He named Gil Hodges for first base, explaining that "he married Joan Lombardi and is an honorary Italian." To satisfy more legitimate ethnic claims, he picked two other first basemen — Tony Bartirome and Joe Pepitone ("he has that Latin look just suited for Ladies' Day").

At second, he lists Tony Lazzeri, Cookie Lavagetto and, surprise, Ernie Fazio, chosen because of his honesty.

"Fazio's the only ballplayer who ever answered with complete candor the question sports writers and sportscasters are always asking a player: 'Why do you lean to a light bat?'" Garagiola explained. "Fazio answered: 'Because it's easier to carry back to the dugout when I strike out.' He's the most honest ballplayer who ever lived."

At shortstop, he selected Phil Rizzuto "for the sake of the kids since he looks like a Little League dropout."

At third base, his vote went to Tony Cuccinello because "he's the only guy who stopped Casey Stengel short." When Stengel asked Tony why he came into third base standing up instead of sliding one day, Joe recalled, Tony told him he had a cigar in his back pocket and didn't want to crumble it. He also included Hall-of-Famer Pie Traynor at third because "the way he played he should have been an Italian."

In right field, it was Tony Conigliaro who "has three

points in his favor — he can hit, run and sing." Joe stressed Conigliaro's value in pointing out he could play during the day and he used to sing at Italian weddings at night. Also in right was Colavito ("anybody with the name Rocco makes such a team official").

In center was Joe DiMaggio ("he's our leader") and in left was Dom DiMaggio ("if we don't take Dom, we can't take Joe — you know, like the father who owns the business.") Also in right, he included Carl Furillo because "he owns a delicatessen and could handle our meal money."

Got To Have A Milo

At pitch were Vic Raschi ("a strong, silent type — and something different on this club"), Sal Maglie ("a mean type who could handle all contract negotiations"), Milo Candino ("you gotta put anybody named Milo on the team for the girls' sake") and Vic Lombardi for the southpaw.

He would change the ending of Casey Stengel's name to "two I's and an I" — Stengelli — and make him manager. He explained that immigration officials, after talking with Casey for five minutes, would accept him as anything.

Umpires would be Augie Donatelli, Lou DiMuro, Al Salerno, Joe Paparella, Art Passarella, Augie Guglielmo because "these six earned it on their own instead of being handed an indicator with their immigration papers like so many Italians.

"In an All-Time Ethnic League, the Italians would do all right because we'd have the umpires on our side, but I don't know if anybody could beat the all-Negro team unless it was the all-Latin American team," Joe said. "An all-Hebrew team might be scarce of players. But you could put Hank Greenberg on the right side of the infield, Andy Cohen on the left side, Moe Berg catching because he could hit in seven languages and Cal Abrams in the outfield. That would give you only four players but with Sandy Koufax pitching that's all you'd need."

The Italians, he noted, would have Frank Sinatra, Tony Bennett and Julius LaRosa to sing the National Anthem — a hard trio to beat.

"Announcers, none," he said. "Only me and Rizzuto. But as a radio engineer, we'd have Marconi. Beat that!"



GARAGIOLA DIMAGGIO

RIZZUTO

BERRA